PRELUDE XVI

THE direction *Largo* is Bach's own. The dotted quavers throughout this piece are to be played as double-dotted (a notation unknown to Bach) in order that their complementary semiquavers may conform to the prevailing rhythm by becoming demisemiquavers, as was always understood by Bach and Handel in such cases.

The upper part of the first bar must always be treated as a single theme, even when, as in bar 6, it seems to be divided between two parts in an ambiguous key-board polyphony. The piece will bear a very slow *tempo* and a fullness of tone which might be dangerous for most of Bach's slow movements. (The tone will grow to its full health and strength only if the player is all the more careful never to force it). In this slow *tempo* the first four bars should have the weight of a big paragraph, and the counter-statement in C minor, with its powerful swing round to D minor, should give the impression that nothing can hasten or arrest the great scheme. Particular point should be made (by gravity, not loudness) of the way in which the opening figure connects the end of each fourth bar with the following fresh start. With bar 9 a third statement leads to what should be felt as from that point onwards an indivisible development right down to the Coda at bar 20; every approach to a close being recognised only to emphasise the irresistible drift onwards. Thus the listener should notice no coincidence between bar 10 and bar 3, the real reference in bar 10 being to bar 4, which looks forward to further stages.

The ~ are all short, except perhaps those in bars 8 and 15, which may be read as a slightly longer shake. They may be supplied to the main theme in parallel places, where playable.

FUGUE XVI

THE Subject and its powerfully contrasted Countersubject are in an all-comprehending Double Counterpoint in the octave, tenth and twelfth, the nature and purpose of which reveals itself in the course of the Fugue. The Exposition (bars 1-17) brings in the four voices (tenor, alto, soprano, bass) with no intervention; a rare phenomenon in Bach and generally indicating some unusual massiveness of design to be revealed later. Three bars of Episode (bars 17-19) combine the joint of Subject to Countersubject in the bass with a lively new figure in the soprano and alto, whereupon the Subject re-enters in the tenor, accompanied by the Countersubject in the bass (bars 20-24). Episode 2 (bars 24-27) develops the line suggested by the first, transferring the new figure to the bass. At bar 28 the Subject and Countersubject appear inverted in the twelfth. The point of this is magnificently evident in the powerful suspended sevenths which have resulted from a combination consisting originally of nothing but concords. At bar 32 the soprano and alto have the two themes in a new position, not as yet an inversion, but evidently not the original harmonies. The independent bass contrives to make those new characteristic sevenths, but, of course, has nothing to do with the actual combination. At bar 36 the bass and soprano, having turned this new position round, show that it is the inversion in the tenth. The alto supplies the sevenths to the harmony. Episode 3 (bars 40-44) carries out the line of its predecessors; and at bar 45 the real motive of Double Counterpoint

Donald Francis Tovey: The Well-Tempered Clavier, Book II
Associated Board, 1924. Printed pp. 110-111.
BWV 885. Complete original pages; adjoining commentary is retained.
Full source scan

in the tenth is revealed. Inversion in the tenth will not by itself produce any special new harmonic character; but its possibility means that either or both members of a combination of melodies can be doubled in thirds or sixths, a luxury easily afforded by *coloratur*-singing above the enslaved and degraded basses of early nineteenth-century Italian opera, but very hardly to be earned and highly to be prized in counterpoint where every note has its thematic rights and duties. Accordingly, the rest of this Fugue proves all that is best in this combination, substituting something still better for the added thirds in the last bar of the Countersubject when that is the doubled theme. At bar 51 the Subject appears in sixths, and at bar 59 we have the complete combination, thirds added to both themes; so that the four parts present inversion in the octave, the tenth (in two ways at once), and the twelfth, with its characteristic sevenths now in completed chords.

At bar 67 the sequential steps of the themes are so used as to allow the thirds (now in the position of tenths) to build themselves up with an effect of Stretto. This comes tersely and boldly to a full close, marked by a powerful break of rhythm (bars 73-74) which is reproduced after three bars of close four-part episodic development of the Countersubject. But this second time (bars 78-79) it marks no close, for the bass, moving from C♯ to D, and from thence to E♭, finds itself occupied in a last entry of the Subject, which it varies by imitating the semiquavers of the Countersubject instead of its own characteristic quaver. (Some MSS. introduce these semiquavers in bar 79, B♭, C, D; but the British Museum autograph reading is really stronger either than that or than the exact thematic B♭ quaver would be.)

It is obvious at a glance that this Fugue is from beginning to end full of power in constant action: and few of Bach's clavier works lend themselves more safely to the display of a big pianoforte tone. The great danger with it is that which attends the first movement of Beethoven's C minor Symphony—viz., loss of power from a tendency, sometimes boyish, sometimes routined, to take a bustling *tempo*. On no account should the player let any passage drift faster than the *tempo* at which after reasonable practice he can comfortably play the left hand of bars 51-54 in his best *forte*, bringing the Countersubject distinctly through the splendid key-board counterpoint which so ingeniously imparts semiquaver movement to it.

As to phrasing, a good hint may be gathered by looking at the strings in the Coda of the first movement of Beethoven's C minor Symphony, and seeing what Weingartner has to say (in *How to Conduct Beethoven's Symphonies*) about the occasion when he found at a rehearsal that somebody had put fussy little cross-accents into the band-parts.

Particular care must be taken not to anticipate the special effect of the added-third combinations, which demand the richest singing tone in all the parts involved. Wherever it happens that a casual pair of thirds or sixths occur elsewhere, only the notes belonging to the thematic voice should be nourished; bars 11, 13, and (dangerously attractive) 22, 35-38. (For this reason it is well not to use the right hand for the tenor part in bars 21-22.)

From bar 45 onwards it does not matter whether the thirds and sixths are thematic or not; they now constitute the high colouring of the picture. At the last bar note the clear indication that the final chord is not to be prolonged. But the rhythm indicates a *ritardando*.

The autograph tie at the end of the Subject in bars 23-24 is no oversight; it gives rise to the rhythm of the following Episode, of which the tie into bar 28 marks the end.